



Archaeology and Anthropological Approaches to Food

As you know from earlier in this module, archaeologists often borrow methods from other disciplines, especially in the sciences, to answer particular archaeological questions. Archaeologists also borrow theoretical approaches from other disciplines, especially sociocultural anthropology, to provide testable expectations of the ways that food and society structured one another in the past. Why do archaeologists so often borrow theories from scholars who study present people? By observing interactions between people, within societies, and among humans, plants, animals, and our broader environment, scholars who study the present gain far more insight into why certain relationships exist and how they come to be than archaeologists, who are only working with a partial glimpse of social relationships in the past through the study of proxy data. As a result, archaeologists may adopt a semiotic or structuralist approach to the study of food, borrowing heavily from theorists such as Barthes and Lévi-Strauss, or follow contemporary concerns in anthropology related to race or identity.

Archaeologists do, however, have some of their own distinct theoretical approaches to the study of food, and we will encounter these in the course modules that follow.